

Session 18: From Judgment to Hope

Key Takeaways

- Ezekiel 33 revisits key phrases and themes from all parts of the book so far.
- The culmination of judgment against Israel comes in the fall of Jerusalem and the destruction of the temple.
- In the biblical story, genuine prophets usually have a different view of the circumstances from those invested in maintaining the status quo such as kings or priests, etc.

Literary Design of Ezekiel 33

This chapter is a crucial transitional section that functions as a bridge between Ezekiel's oracles of judgment in chapters 1-32 and his oracles of hope in chapters 34-48. The news of Jerusalem's fall is at the center of the chapter (Ezek. 33:21-22), and there is a symmetrical ordering of material around verses 21-22 focusing on Ezekiel's status as a true prophet (his predictions came true), and how Israel still needs to listen to the prophetic word and respond.

- A—33:1-11
- B—33:12-20
- C—33:21-22
- B'—33:23-29
- A'—33:30-33

Ezekiel's Role as a Watchman to Israel (Ezek. 33:1-9)

This section repeats 3:17-21, and the two sections act as a frame around the beginning and end of Ezekiel's oracles of judgment. The difference is that 3:17-21 was a private word to Ezekiel, while 33:1-9 is the prophet making public what he has been trying to do for the last seven years.

Looking back, Ezekiel has been trying to get their attention through every means possible. Ezekiel acted faithfully as a watchman, he warned the exiles and Jerusalem of the coming judgment, and their blood is no longer on his hands.

Looking forward, he will function as a watchman for years to come, only his message will change dramatically to one of hope (chapters 34-48).

Yahweh's Will for the Righteous and Wicked (Ezek. 33:10-20)

33:10 shows the first sign of Ezekiel's message being effective! But he's done too good a job. The exiles own their role in the city's destruction, but to the point of hopelessness.

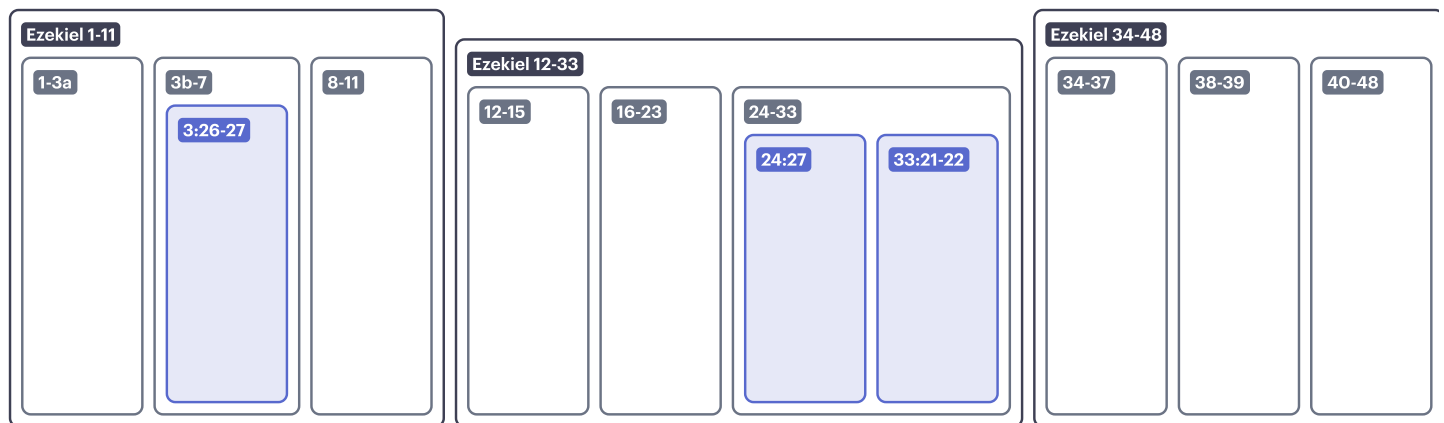
33:11-20 repeats the message from chapter 18, but this time with a receptive audience. The message becomes a reminder of how the exiles are not locked into judgment from their past sins. They can repent, they can change, and Yahweh will honor their change of heart if they respond to his message.

Messenger With News of Jerusalem's Destruction (Ezek. 33:21-22)

In January 585 B.C.E., Ezekiel is vindicated as a true prophet when a survivor (surely among a larger group of exiles) from Jerusalem comes bearing news of the city's destruction.

This passage is the fulfillment of the divine promise in 24:27, and it also links back to 3:26-27 where God promised to remove the divinely imposed inability to speak. This signals a new season in Ezekiel's prophetic ministry, which still has 12 more years (40:1 dates to 573 B.C.E.) as he begins to deliver a message of hope.

Notice how the macro-design of Ezekiel makes clear that we have reached a major transition in the book's flow of thought.



Ezekiel 1-48. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Ezekiel 3:24-27 NASB*

²⁴ ... Go, shut yourself up in your house. ²⁵ As for you, son of man, they will put ropes on you and bind you with them so that you cannot go out among them. ²⁶ Moreover, **I will make your tongue stick to the roof of your mouth so that you will be mute** and cannot be a mediator, for they are a rebellious house. ²⁷ But when I speak to you, I will open your mouth and you will say to them, "Thus says the Lord God." He who hears, let him hear; and he who refuses, let him refuse; for they are a rebellious house.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Ezekiel 24:26-27 NASB*

²⁶ that on that day the refugee will come to you with information for your ears. ²⁷ On that day **your mouth will be opened** to the refugee, and **you will speak and be mute no longer**. Thus you will be a sign to them, and they will know that I am the LORD.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Ezekiel 33:21-22 NASB*

²¹ Now in the twelfth year of our exile, on the fifth of the tenth month, the refugees from Jerusalem came to me, saying, "The city has been struck down." ²² Now the hand of the LORD had been upon me in the evening, before the refugees came. **And he opened my mouth at the time they came to me in the morning; so my mouth was opened and I was no longer mute.**

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

False Hopes of the Survivors in Jerusalem (Ezek. 33:23-29)

Ezekiel learns of survivors in Jerusalem (33:24; see 2 Kgs. 25:12) who believe their survival is a sign of divine choice (like Abraham), and the empty cities and lands of Israel are a divine gift as an inheritance for a new Israel (also like Abraham, see Isa. 51:2 for the same analogy used to make a positive point).

Ezekiel uses language from chapter 18 to describe their evil behavior, matching the language used in 33:10-20.

Ezekiel challenges this view, accusing them of the same lack of self-awareness as the exiles: The future of God's promises lay with the exiles, not with the ruined survivors in Jerusalem (the same message was expressed by Jer. 24 about the good and bad figs).

Ezekiel's Prophetic Word Still Not Taken to Heart (Ezek. 33:30-33)

Just as Ezekiel was warned at the beginning about the opposition he would face (chapters 2-3), so now as his reputation soars as a true prophet (he is the talk of the town, 33:30), he is warned of the opposite response: flattery.

People will flock to hear him, give him lip service, but the reality is that their hearts are as selfish as ever, and their behavior remains unchanged (33:31). Ezekiel must resist the urge to become an entertainer (33:32) and remain faithful to his call as a true prophet (33:33).

Reflection Question

Ezekiel 33 revisits themes from all over the first part of the book. How would you summarize the key themes of this chapter?